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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

GENERAL ASSEMBLY

Pritzker skeptical of transit plan

House Democrats' \$1.5B tax and fee package to address looming shortfall likely dead on arrival

By **Jeremy Gorner,**
Olivia Olander
and **Dan Petrella**
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Gov. JB Pritzker on Wednesday poured cold water on Illinois House Democrats' latest tax and fee proposals to overhaul the Chicago region's mass transit systems — prompting

pushback from at least one of those lawmakers who said he would like to see the governor's suggestions to fix the problem.

Just hours after House Democrats proposed a sweeping menu of options to raise \$1.5 billion — including new taxes on streaming services and billionaires, adding fees onto tickets for large sporting events and concerts and allow-

ing speed cameras to populate Chicago's suburbs — Pritzker all but declared the measure dead on arrival.

"I have to say, they sprung a whole bunch of things that have never been seen before. So it's very hard to evaluate in a short period of time. I think there's a whole lot of work the legislature still needs to do," Pritzker said during an unrelated news conference outside of Taylorville, about 30 miles from

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Gov. JB Pritzker answers reporters' questions about a Democratic tax and fee plan to overhaul Chicagoland's mass transit systems during a Wednesday visit to the Curtin Family Farm near Taylorville. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



Sophomore Piper Jade Laskey Terry, 15, and her father, John Terry, walk to The Chicago High School for the Arts on Oct. 14. **ANTONIO PEREZ/TRIBUNE**

A DARK CLOUD OVER CHARTERS

Students, families rally around CPS contract schools with uncertain futures

By **Kate Perez**
Chicago Tribune

The halls that house The Chicago High School for the Arts have a history of creative expression coupled with resistance, and Andrea Gonzáles knows them well.

The senior visual art student is the second generation in her family to study in the vast building in Humboldt Park — once home to Lafayette Elementary School — the school her mother attended in the 1980s — decades before it closed in 2013.

Adorning the walls is a mural depicting protests sparked by that closure over a decade ago — moments memorialized in art by students who attend ChiArts, which took over the building in 2014. Gonzáles is pictured with her mother in what was her fifth-grade classroom when it was Lafayette Elementary, smiling at each other from different desks.

Earlier this month, when ChiArts' board said it would not renew its contract with Chicago Public

"It really is like nothing else I've ever heard of. It's very inclusive, it's very educational. ... You don't get that level of art training in other places."

— *Sophomore Piper Jade Laskey Terry, on her experience at The Chicago High School for the Arts*

Schools, Gonzáles and her peers feared history repeating itself — a school they love facing possible closure.

So, like their predecessors did over a decade ago, they protested.

ChiArts' board cited a financial shortfall as part of its decision, following a pattern of uncertainty around CPS charter and contract schools that has plagued the district for decades. Charter and contracted schools are publicly funded and overseen by CPS but privately managed by independent boards. Those boards dictate decisions behind applying for contract renewals and school closures.

The uncertainty surrounding her school's future weighs heavily on Gonzáles. Being in the building, knowing what it meant to people like her mother, it feels like ChiArts is living up to Lafayette's history in a negative way, she said.

"I don't want it to be repeated like a generational curse," Gonzáles said. "It's the same building, the

Turn to Charters, Page 6

Activists want feds to face charges

Group argues actions in Trump's blitz are breaking state laws

By **Rick Pearson**
Chicago Tribune

A left-leaning voters' rights group that has pushed for President Donald Trump's removal from office over alleged constitutional abuses is now asking Illinois officials to investigate and prosecute alleged violations of state law by federal immigration enforcement agents deployed in "Operation Midway Blitz."

In letters sent this week to Gov. JB Pritzker, Attorney General Kwame Raoul and Cook County State's Attorney Eileen O'Neill Burke, all three of whom are Democrats, and Chicago police Superintendent Larry Snelling, the Free Speech for People campaign contends "federal agents have repeatedly committed criminal acts that are not immunized by federal law."

"We applaud you for establishing the Illinois Accountability Commission and empowering it to refer" violations to agencies empowered to investigate and enforce such laws, the group's letter to Pritzker says about the governor's creation of the new panel last week. "Although the executive order establishing the commission requires it to create an initial status report by Jan. 16, we encourage the commission to immediately refer serious incidents for further investigation by relevant law enforcement officers."

So far, that doesn't appear to be on Pritzker's agenda.

Last week, even after U.S. Deputy Attorney General Todd Blanche tagged Pritzker in a social media post threatening legal action against California

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MORE COVERAGE

Abughazaleh, others charged

A federal grand jury has indicted six protesters, including 9th District congressional candidate Katherine "Kat" Abughazaleh, for allegedly conspiring to impede an ICE agent while he was driving into the Broadview ICE facility in the suburb last month. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

■ A federal appeals court ruled Wednesday that Border Patrol Cmdr. Gregory Bovino does not have to appear daily in court to brief a federal judge on feds' use of force — at least for now. **Chicagoland, Page 4**

Downstate jury finds deputy guilty in killing of Sonya Massey

By **Jeremy Gorner**
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — A downstate jury found Sean Grayson, a former Sangamon County sheriff's deputy, guilty of second-degree murder Wednesday in the killing last year of Sonya Massey inside her home near Springfield, a case that sparked national outrage and calls for police reforms.

The mostly white, 12-member jury in Peoria announced its verdict one week after testimony began in a case that focused on graphic police body camera footage of Grayson, who is white, fatally shooting Massey, a 36-year-old Black mother of two, after he repeatedly shouted at her to drop a pot of boiling water. It also centered on the prosecution's accusations that Grayson, now

31, repeatedly failed to follow law enforcement policies or training, damaging testimony from Grayson's partner that suggested Grayson didn't do enough to help save Massey's life after shooting her, and Grayson's own testimony that shooting Massey was a way to "match" the level of her threatening actions.

The verdict is the culmination of an incident that spurred

protests across the country that highlighted the treatment of Black citizens at the hands of law enforcement officers, including a statement from then-President Joe Biden, who said Massey's death "reminds us that all too often Black Americans face fears for their safety in ways many of the rest of us do not."

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